incident.[125] Given his closeness with both Indira and Rajiv, Dixit's words carried weight. Dixit had convinced the Indian leadership of Najibullah's political prowess in general and pro-India attitude in particular as early as 1983, almost at the same time Moscow started debating Karmal's potential successor. Najibullah's key Khalqi competitor in the mid-1980s was none other than Sarwari. Curiously, both were former spy chiefs, both were proactive and ruthless, and both had links with (rival) Soviet intelligence agencies. Sarwari had the *Glavnoye razvedyvatel'noye upravleniye* (GRU) or the Main Intelligence Directorate's backing, whereas Najibullah had the KGB's (and resultantly Indian R&AW's) support.[126]

The GRU's argument against Najibullah was that his apparent Pasthun nationalism would (and did) become a hindrance to the Soviet withdrawal. They feared that Najibullah would not be able to undertake a genuine reconciliation with the Mujahideen. Sarwari, a Tajik from Ghazni, on the other hand, a GRU report argued, had support of many PDPA leaders, could be a moderating force, and also reconcile both domestic ethnic groups and the Mujahideen.[127] The GRU was correct about Najibullah's anti-Pakistan and pro-Pashtunistan tendencies but its assessment of Sarwari as moderate was mythical at best. Having persecuted hundreds of dissidents, Sarwari was anything but moderate. His unique selling point for some in the GRU was his contacts with the Mujahideen (especially Hekmatyar) and by corollary, Pakistan. The KGB, however, had more influence in the CPSU politburo than the GRU on Afghanistan. It was able to convince the CPSU that Najibullah, known as the 'Ox' for his powerful build, was best suited to lead the reconciliation process on terms that would secure Soviet interests in the country even after the withdrawal, and who would remain in power for a considerable time with the requisite support. Both Gorbachev and Rajiv liked the sound of it.[128]

By the late 1980s, however, more than India's dependence on Moscow, the second causal driver of Rajiv's political closeness with Najibullah was the deterioration of both India and Afghanistan's relations with Pakistan. Zia had replicated the 'Afghan model' of subversion in both Indian-administered Kashmir and Punjab. With his conciliatory diplomacy with Reagan and Gorbachev failing miserably, Rajiv's regional policy took an unduly muscular